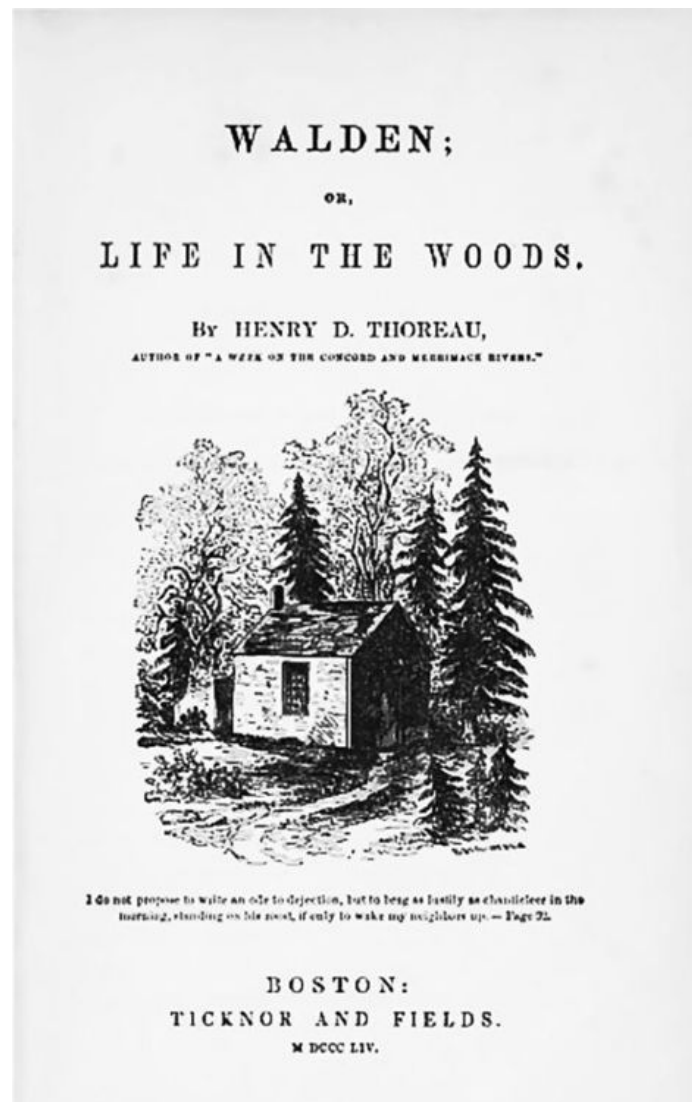


Transcendentalism



In his 1836 essay *Nature*, Ralph Waldo Emerson set out a philosophy based on the fundamental goodness of both man and nature, similar in some respects to European Romanticism. At its heart was the idea of independence from the prevailing political, social and religious institutions, replaced with a simple, life of rugged self-reliance in harmony with nature. In that way, individuals could achieve their full potential, and enrich their consciousness. Emerson placed great emphasis on individualism and the possibility that we can each build our own world, discovering for ourselves the meaning of values such as truth and goodness, but he also advocated

simple religious faith as practised by the nonconformist Christians of the time. Among his followers was Henry David Thoreau, who developed the ideas of individualism and nonconformism into an anti-establishment philosophy that verged on anarchism (see [Civil disobedience](#)). Thoreau also took the simple life to heart, presenting in his book *Walden* (1854) a vision of a community in harmony with nature that anticipates later environmentalism.